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Information Visualization

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Depression and Suicide in American Youth: The Necessity of Early Intervention

The United States, especially its adolescent population, is in a severe mental health crisis. Survey data shows that approximately 16% of American adolescents experienced a major depressive episode in the year 2024 (Center for Behavioral Health Statistics and Quality). Furthermore, suicide is the second most common cause of death for US adolescents aged 10-14, and the third most common for those aged 15-19 (Centers for Disease Control and Protection). Children and teenagers all across America are suffering from mental health problems every day, and they may not be getting the treatment they need to survive. Therefore, to avoid losing more young lives to suicide, early intervention for mental health in adolescents is crucial to catch and treat depression before it can worsen.

Adolescence is a peak period for the development of mental health conditions. Approximately 1 in 5 US adolescents aged 12-17 have a diagnosed behavioral or mental health condition (Sappenfield et al.), and millions more suffer from undiagnosed conditions. It is undeniable that mental health issues are incredibly common in teens today, and there are reasons why adolescents are so susceptible to mental health problems. The World Health Organization explains that "Physical, emotional and social changes... can make adolescents vulnerable to mental health problems." Things such as exposure to adversity, social pressures to conform, media influence, and identity exploration are both natural parts of being a teenager and risk

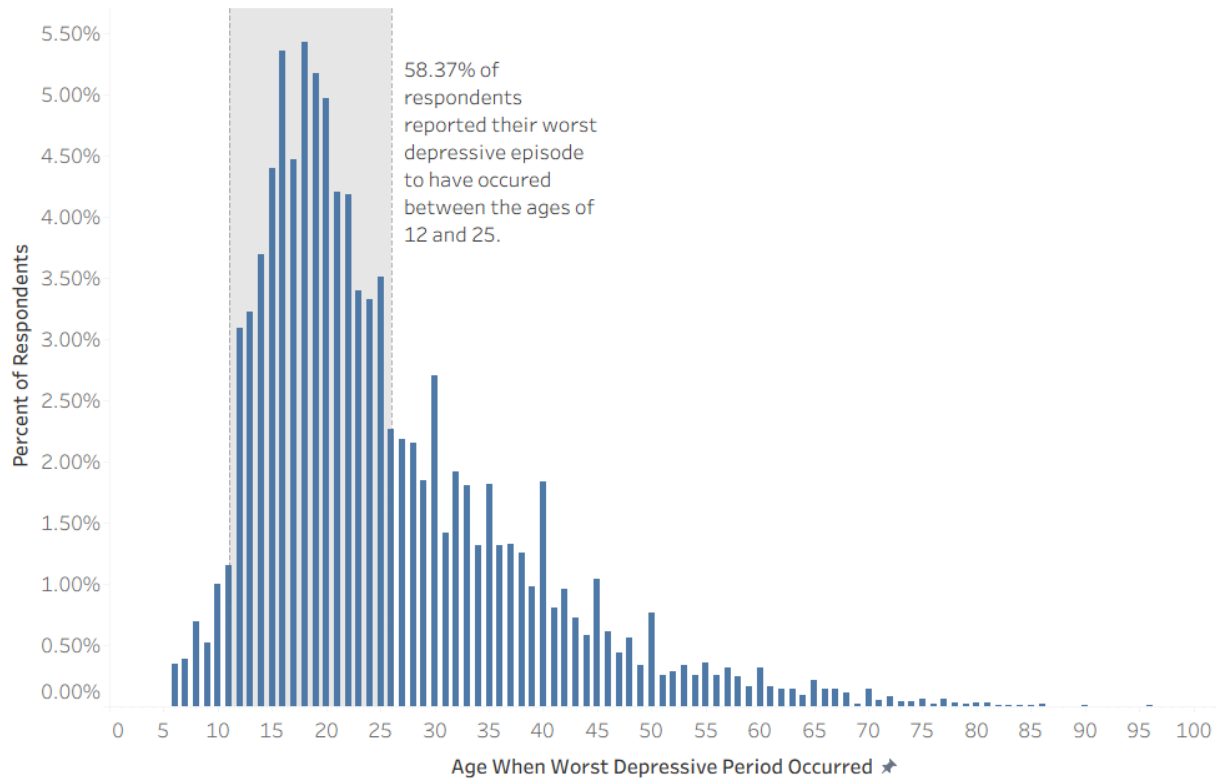
factors for developing mental health conditions. It's no mystery as to why teenagers are so commonly anxious and depressed.

Accordingly, data from the 2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health (NSDUH) reveals that over half of American adults who have experienced at least one depressive episode in their life (characterized by negative lifestyle changes, decreased concentration and memory, and feelings of low self-worth) report that the worst depressive episode of their life occurred between the ages of 12 and 25, with the most common ages reported being 16 and 18 years old (see Figure 1). This further evidences that the adolescent years before the prefrontal cortex fully develops are a hotspot for depression and mental health crises, which is why parents, teachers, and other community leaders must remain vigilant for warning signs of mental health conditions such as depression in teenagers.

Figure 1:

Worst Periods of Depression Most Commonly Occur in Youth

Americans were most commonly between the ages of 12 to 25 when they experienced their worst two-week period of depressive symptoms, with peak ages being 16 and 18 years old.



Source: 2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health, Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, <https://www.samhsa.gov/data/data-we-collect/nsduh-national-survey-drug-use-and-health>

Although adolescent suicide rates have recently been on the decline, owing largely to "reductions in suicide rates among boys and young men"(Assimon), teen suicide is still a major issue in America today. Although adolescents have the lowest suicide rate per 100,000 people (with people 85+ having the highest), suicide still ranks highest as a cause of death for that age group than for any other (Suicide Prevention Research Center). Globally, the United States of America stands as a nation with one of the highest adolescent (specifically ages 15-19) suicide

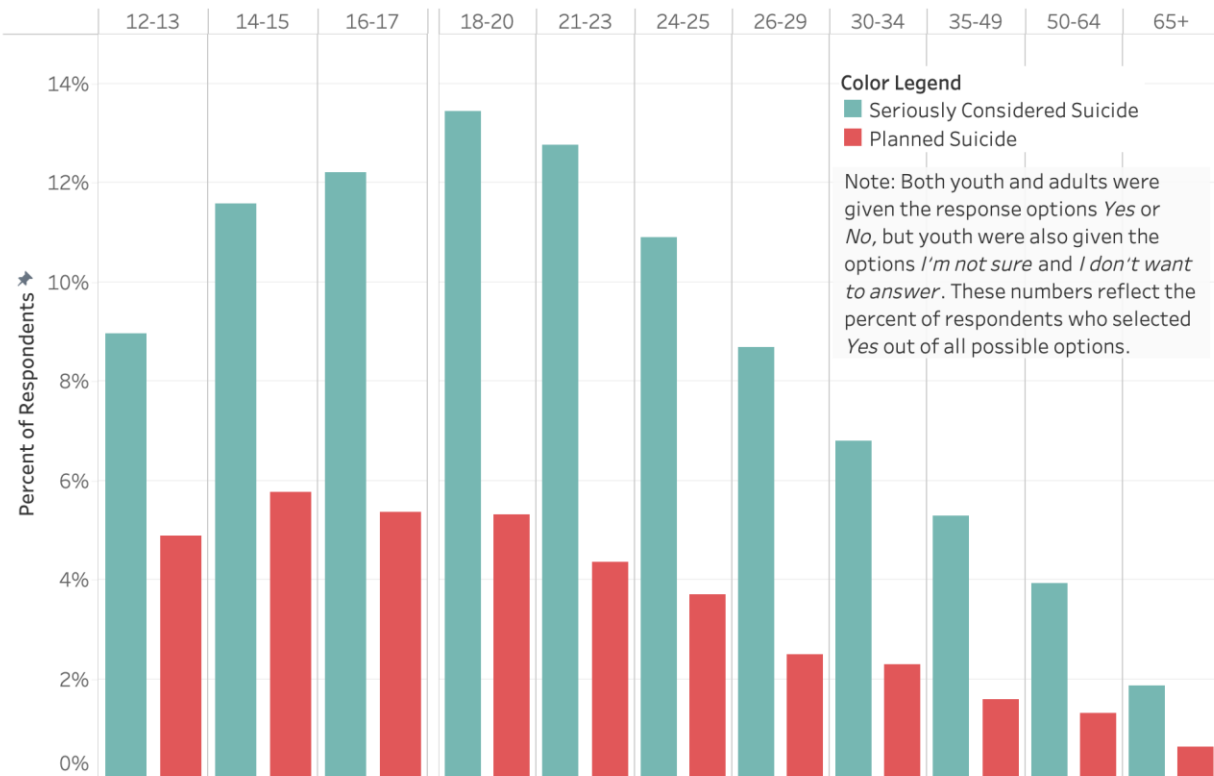
rates worldwide as of the most recent data available (World Bank Group). It is clear to see that the issue of adolescent suicide is a serious problem in America today.

To further emphasize this point, data collected from the 2024 NSDUH suggests that for Americans, suicidal thoughts peak in the late years of adolescence, as respondents age 18-20 self-reported had most commonly had serious suicidal thoughts in the past year, with 13.43% of respondents in that age group reporting having seriously considered suicide in 2024 (see Figure 2). However, it was the 14 to 15-year-old age group who had the highest percentage of respondents that self-reported actually planning their suicide, totaling 5.78% of respondents in the age group. This coincides with findings that suicide is a more common cause of death for early teens than late teens (Centers for Disease Control and Protection) and highlights the need for diligent monitoring and interventions for signs of depression in young adolescents.

Figure 2:

Both Suicidal Thoughts and Planning Peak Before The Age of 21

Respondents between the age of 18-20 most reported having seriously considering suicide in the past year, but respondents between the ages of 14-15 most reported having actually planned it.



Source: 2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health, Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, <https://www.samhsa.gov/data/data-we-collect/nsduh-national-survey-drug-use-and-health>

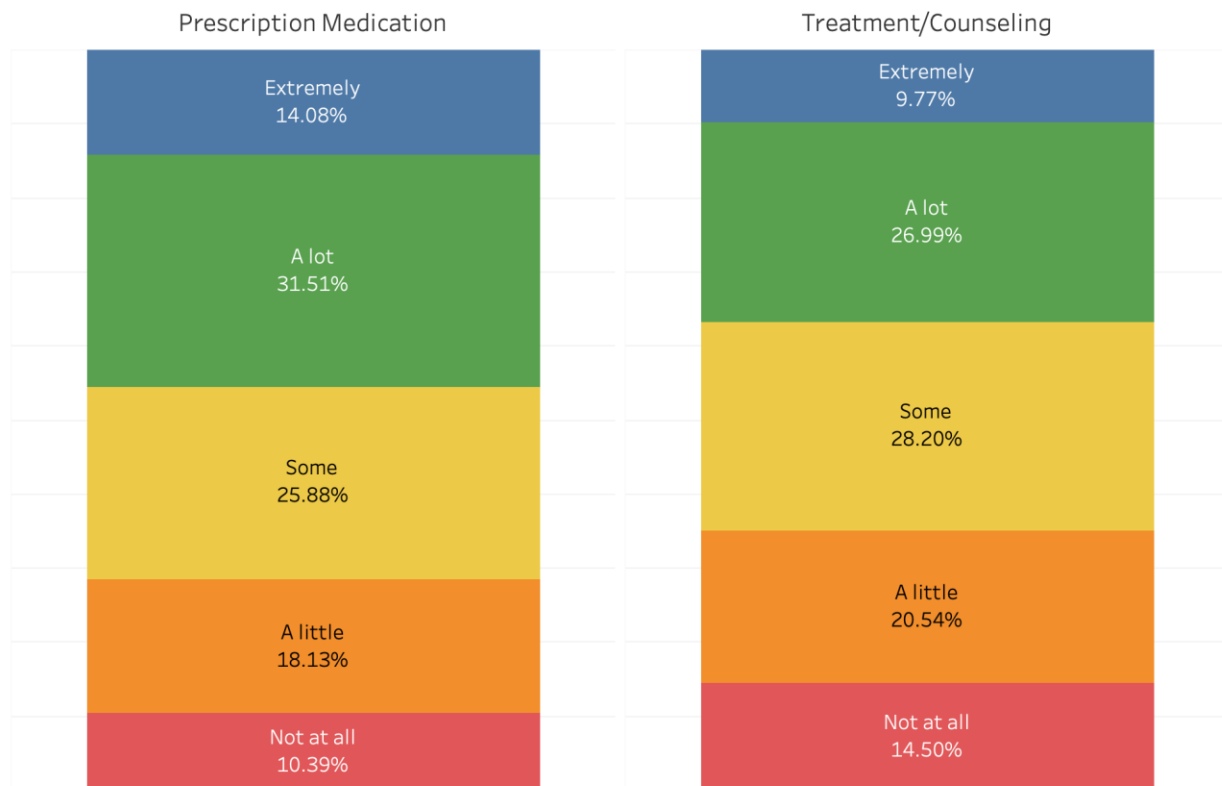
The data makes it clear that something needs to be done to help adolescents with their mental health issues, and early intervention is one of the best methods for the job. Early intervention programs that have been implemented in other countries have seen significant success. One such example is in Australia, where in 2006 they created a government-funded initiative called headspace (intentionally not capitalized) that provided early intervention services to adolescents with emerging mental health disorders (McGorry and Mei). Evaluations of the initiative found

that headspace "was effective in significantly reducing suicide ideation and self-harm, and in decreasing the number of absent school or work days" (McGorry and Mei).

The evidence supporting early intervention is not just anecdotal; self-assessments by teens themselves support the efficacy of mental health treatments in adolescents. Data from the 2024 NSDUH found that about 65% of adolescents who received therapy/counseling in 2024 found it at least somewhat helpful, with over 35% regarding it as very helpful. Additionally, about 70% of adolescents taking prescription medication for mood disorders found their treatment at least somewhat helpful, with around 45% finding it very helpful (see Figure 3). This shows that mental health services for adolescents routinely bring about perceivable improvement in the mental health of teenagers.

Figure 3:

Over One-Third of Youths Found Their Mental Health Treatment Significantly Helpful
However, Americans under 18 who took prescription medication for their mood in 2024 tended to see their treatment as more helpful than those undergoing therapy or counseling.



Source: 2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health, Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration,
<https://www.samhsa.gov/data/data-we-collect/nsduh-national-survey-drug-use-and-health>

So, how do we actually implement early intervention in America? One tactic is to expand the mental health provider workforce by incentivizing people to become mental health professionals and reducing barriers to receiving the necessary qualifications (Gillison). This would increase the prevalence of mental health services in America, making them more easily accessible to teenagers across the country. Another tactic is focusing on increasing preventative measures for mental health conditions by educating the youth on self-regulation tools such as

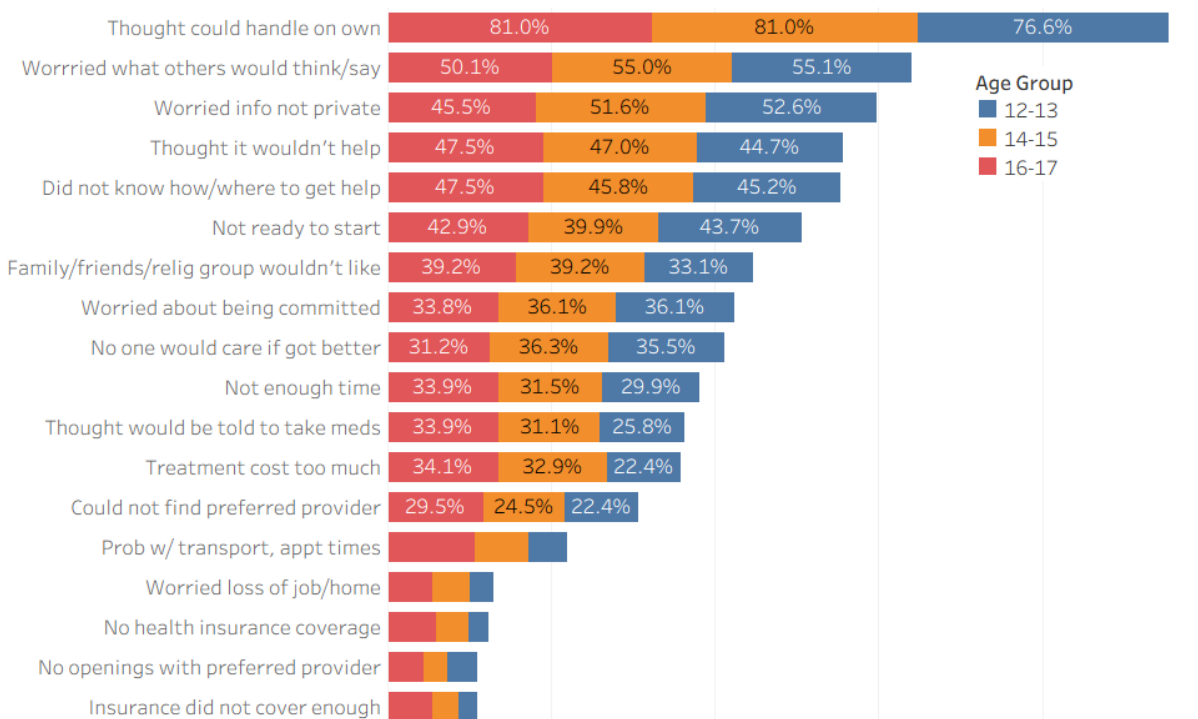
mindfulness, self-care and healthy coping mechanisms (Gillison). This could have the potential to nip mental health conditions in the bud before they can ever start.

However, while these methods are both useful, the former takes quite a long time, and the latter doesn't help people who are already suffering. In contrast, a tactic we can implement right now that helps all adolescents is educating and increasing awareness about mental health and the treatment services available to teenagers today (Gillison). This may seem trivial, but data suggests that it is exactly what adolescents struggling with mental health problems really need to seek treatment. NSDUH data from 2024 reveals that the biggest factors pushing teens away from getting mental health treatment aren't financial or logistical issues, but rather stigmas surrounding mental health and lack of information/education about mental health services. Figure 4 shows that the three most common reasons why US adolescents ages 12-17 who considered getting mental health treatment in 2024 didn't follow through were that they thought they could handle their mental health on their own, that they were worried what people would think and say, and that they were worried information would not be kept private. This suggests that the best way to promote utilization of mental health services in adolescents is to speak openly about mental health and increase education about available mental health services.

Figure 4:

Adolescents Who Are Considering Mental Health Treatment Aren't Following Through Because of Stigma and Misconceptions

US teens who decided against seeking mental health in 2024 overwhelmingly attributed the choice to the belief they could handle it on their own, with social and privacy concerns also on their mind.



Source: 2024 National Survey on Drug Use and Health, Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration, <https://www.samhsa.gov/data/data-we-collect/nsduh-national-survey-drug-use-and-health>

In conclusion, America is in the middle of a mental health crisis, and early intervention might be the key to ending it. The best part of early intervention is that it is something that every person can implement at this very moment. The keys to catching mental health conditions before they fester are vigilance and education. Know the early warning signs of depression and watch for them in the adolescents in your life. Be aware of the mental health resources in your community and help teenagers to connect to them when they need it. Tear down existing stigmas by speaking out about mental health and reminding others that it's okay to not be okay. With

these small, simple actions, every single person has the power to make meaningful change in their community - and save young lives before it's too late.

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